



» ANALYSIS

Reality check

Delayed matches, injured stars, and poor pitches — the Club World Cup has highlighted **systemic problems** FIFA must urgently address before the next World Cup.

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A fresh model, more exciting clashes involving big teams, and a chance for small teams to shine — these were some of the primary agendas behind FIFA president Gianni Infantino launching a rebranded version of the Club World Cup (CWC).

Originally an annual affair, featuring the winners of just continental competitions, the rebranded version boasts a 32-team tournament, to be held once every four years.

However, the tournament started drawing criticism from bodies like FIFPRO and the World Leagues Forum due to the impact it is expected to have on fixture

congestion and player welfare.

Global players' union FIFPRO, in collaboration with 70 medical and performance experts, released a study on June 12 (three days before the start of the CWC), which states that professional footballers should be allowed at least a four-week off-season break, plus a minimum four-week retraining period before returning to competition. It also recommends mandatory mid-season breaks and mandatory consideration of the travel burden on players.

To put this into context, let us take the example of Manchester City and Chelsea, the two teams that represented the Premier League in the CWC. While City got knocked out in the Round of 16, Chelsea, which reached the final and eventually won the title, will have a gap of only five weeks before their domestic season

starts on August 15. Also, Chelsea's first game of the CWC took place on June 16, just 19 days after its UEFA Conference League final win over Real Betis.

Humans, not machines

The physical ability of sportspeople is often taken for granted, and footballers are not exempt from this. One of the major criticisms FIFA has faced for rebranding the CWC is the neglect of player welfare, with the global football body seemingly oblivious to the physical and mental stress a player endures throughout the season.

If we take Europe's top-five leagues into consideration, Premier League, La Liga, and Serie A teams play 38 games while Bundesliga and Ligue 1 teams play 34 matches. This increases for some teams depending